

Action Plan COARA

2024-2027

1. Summary

The Universidade de Vigo (UVigo) ratified its adherence to the Coalition for Advancing Research Assessment (CoARA) in December 2022.

The adhesion to CoARA involves the design of an action plan to improve the quality, execution, and impact of research.

UVigo has fulfilled this commitment approving the present action plan, which incorporates the principles of diversity, inclusion, collaboration etc, as the basis for assessment criteria and processes.

This program for the progressive reform of internal research evaluation systems takes into account the commitments of the "Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment" and the recommendations of the document "Support for CoARA Signatories in the Preparation of Action Plans".

The action plan also incorporates a consultative and participatory process, involving researchers from various disciplines and career stages to provide their valuable feedback during the initial design phase.

Moreover, the plan is strategically aligned, fostering synergies and opportunities with other ongoing initiatives at UVigo, such as:

- The Human Resources Strategy for Researchers (HRS4R), to support a better implementation of the Charter principles in its policies and practices
- The Open, Transparent and Merit-Based Recruitment of Researchers (OTM-R, to ensure that the best person is hired for each position, guaranteeing equal opportunities and access, facilitating developing an international career (cooperation, competition, mobility), and making research careers more attractive.

- ATHENA European University, an alliance of ten higher education and research institutions from different geographical areas in Europe, to offer student-centred curricula delivered jointly on inter-university campuses, where different mobility options are available. All this in an interdisciplinary cooperative approach to address the problems of today's Europe.

2. Introduction

There's a growing demand within the academic sphere for a reevaluation of research assessment methodologies.

Initiatives such as the San Francisco Declaration on Research Assessment (DORA), the Leiden Manifesto for Research Metrics (2015), and the joint position of the European University Association (EUA) and Science Europe (2019) emphasise the urgent need for an actualization of the research evaluation practices.

The Coalition for Advancing Research Assessment (CoARA) aims to redefine the evaluation of scientific research and represents a collective effort to redesign how research is assessed.

ANECA's alignment with CoARA has involved regulatory amendments, notably reflected in the LOSU and Royal Decree 678/2023, along with the Resolution of 19 December 2023 of the General Secretariat of Universities on the 2023 criteria for six-year research periods. Furthermore, the first National Open Science Strategy (ENCA) 2023-2027 prioritizes the establishment of new research evaluation mechanisms and an incentives framework to foster open science practices.

CoARA advocates for a qualitative evaluation of research, with peer review as a cornerstone, complemented by responsible use of bibliometric indicators. Moreover, CoARA recognizes the imperative to accommodate the inherent diversity in research outcomes, methodologies, and practices across different disciplines and career stages. Furthermore, CoARA fosters ethical conduct in research, the principles of open science, and the dissemination of research works.

By joining COARA, the University of Vigo embraces all these principles and commitments.

3. Assessment of research at Universidade de Vigo

The commitment of the Universidade de Vigo to the transformation of research towards a more qualitative, transparent, fair, diverse and inclusive evaluation is shown by the fact that the internal calls for research activities have for some time now introduced elements of qualitative evaluation, such as the assessment of the diversity of results beyond publications:

- ✓ patents,
- ✓ contracts,
- ✓ dissemination of results
- ✓ licensing of research results,
- ✓ creation of spin-offs, collaboration with companies,
- ✓ projects with a social impact

and more recently, open access criteria.

These criteria have already been implemented in some assessment activities at the UVigo, such as:

- Value merits of scientific production and transfer production.
- UVigo research staff mobility calls
- Predoctorals grants

The UVigo wants to foster an evaluation environment that enhances incentives for high-quality or relevant research.

With this purpose, UVigo has designed this CoARA action plan, to gradually increase the significance of quantitative peer review, all through the responsible use of bibliometric indicators.

4. Universidade de Vigo Action Plan

PHASES	LINES	ACTIONS	TIMEFRAME	DESCRIPTION
PHASE A	Establishment of the COARA Committee	Human and material resources	2024	Creation of the working group for the elaboration, implementation and monitoring of the COARA action plan. Establishment of regular follow-up meetings Provision of resources
PHASE B	COARA Strategy	Visibility/Communication	2024	Make visible the principles of CoARA and the institution's commitment to them.
	Identification of the current situation	Diagnosis of research activity assessment procedures	2024	Analysis of the evaluation methods applied to research structure (groups, departments, researchers) concerning funding, staff selection, hiring, and academic career progression at the Universidade de Vigo and in institutions within the national and European context.

PHASE C	Involvement of the institutional community in the change process	Training/outreach/awareness raising	2024	Cultivate awareness and install a culture of rigorous scientific assessment across the institution.
		Research career path	2024	Design of researchers training paths
		Public consultation	2024	Involve researchers in the evaluation reform process collecting their perspectives and expectations regarding the enhancement of the evaluation system
		Discussion with stakeholders	2024	Involve the rest of the stakeholders in the process
PHASE D	Implementing change tools	Definition of the new assessment system	2025	Selection of the new criteria to be implemented
		Search for tools to implement CoARA criteria	2025	Design and creation of the new tools for the new system
PHASE E	Pilot Test	Pilot initiative for revised assessment protocols	2026	Design a pilot project specifically targeted at refining research incentive mechanisms, aimed at fostering an environment conducting to research excellence.

PHASE F	Global implementation	Progressive global implementation	2026-2027	Implementation of revised assessment protocols in alignment with CoARA.
	Dissemination & Outreach	Communication activities	2027	Disseminate the transformation process of Universidade de Vigo Foster collaboration and knowledge exchange with other universities and stakeholders.